

How should we determine what research questions to ask in any research domain (strategic research planning)?

DoView Strategic Research Planning shifts the focus in any research domain on any topic from designing isolated studies to identifying the knowledge gaps most critical for the field's progress. Instead of beginning with 'How do we study this particular issue?' research planners start by asking 'Which high-stakes decisions or theoretical debates must the next set of evidence inform?' Research questions, methods, scale and sequencing are then chosen to maximise their contribution to those priorities. Adopting this approach requires changes in funding rules, governance, research culture, commissioning procedures and investigator practice.

To work at this broader level, researchers, funders, and end-users need a framework that links individual studies to the wider outcomes the discipline or sector seeks. This happens at the moment through literature reviews and conference discussions. DoView Strategic Research Planning complements this by providing a formal way of representing the research domain and then mapping potential research questions onto it. This is done by developing a DoView strategy/outcomes diagram of the research area.

The concept is that researchers, funders and stakeholders are brought together to develop or review the relevant DoView diagram of the research domain. They then identify the priority research questions on the DoView. The DoView, marked up with the priority research questions, is then widely disseminated within the funding and research community.

Then, when research findings are produced, they are used to update the 'This-Then' logic captured within the DoView. This new version of the DoView is then used in the next iteration of research planning and subsequently guides research funding decisions. The DoView Strategic Research Planning Tool (G3) sets out the steps in the process. A number of the steps in the process use other DoView Planning tools but adapted for research planning. For instance, Mapping a Set of Evaluation Questions Onto a DoView Strategy/Outcomes Diagram (G6).